

**Digital Theatre Convergence as the New Normal: A Performance of Otun Rasheed's
The Third World War in Perspective**

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ABSTRACT

*This study examines the influence of digital technologies on contemporary theatre practice through a livestreamed performance of Otun Rasheed's *The Third World War*, staged by final-year students in the Department of Theatre Arts at Plateau State University, Nigeria. The study addresses the growing need to understand how digital convergence reshapes theatrical production, audience engagement, and performance spaces within African theatre practice. Using a qualitative case study approach, data were collected through observation of the production process, audience feedback, livestream analytics, and documentation of the Facebook Live broadcast. Findings reveal that digital technologies enhanced accessibility, expanded audience reach beyond the physical venue, and encouraged new forms of audience participation. However, challenges such as network instability, poor audio quality, funding constraints, and platform restrictions undermined the livestream's effectiveness. Drawing on Philip Auslander's theory of liveness and Henry Jenkins' convergence culture theory, the study argues that digital theatre convergence offers significant opportunities for innovation while raising concerns about technological limitations and theatrical authenticity. The study contributes to emerging scholarship on African digital theatre practices and virtual spectatorship.*

Keywords: Digital Theatre, Livestreaming, Audience Engagement, Virtual Spectatorship, Theatre Convergence

INTRODUCTION

The increasing integration of digital technologies into everyday life has transformed numerous sectors, including education, communication, entertainment, and the creative arts. Theatre, traditionally dependent on the physical co-presence of performers and audiences, has not remained untouched by this transformation. The emergence of digital technologies such as livestreaming platforms, social media applications, virtual reality, and interactive media has redefined the processes of theatrical production, distribution, and audience engagement.

Recent developments in digital theatre have expanded opportunities for theatre practitioners to reach audiences beyond conventional performance spaces. Livestreaming technologies, in particular, have enabled performances to be viewed remotely while preserving varying degrees of audience participation and interaction. These developments have generated significant scholarly interest in questions of liveness, audience engagement, accessibility, and the future of theatrical practice in technologically mediated environments.

Within the Nigerian context, studies on digital theatre remain relatively limited despite the growing adoption of digital technologies by theatre practitioners. Consequently, there is a need for empirical investigations into how digital convergence affects theatrical performance and audience experiences in local contexts.

This study investigates the livestreamed production of Otun Rasheed's *The Third World War*, performed by final-year students in the Department of Theatre Arts at Plateau State University. Through this case study, the research examines how digital technologies reshape audience engagement, performance spaces, and theatrical communication.

RESEARCH GAP

Although considerable scholarship exists on digital theatre in Europe and North America, limited attention has been paid to livestreamed theatrical productions within Nigerian university theatre practice. Existing studies often emphasise technological innovations while paying insufficient attention to audience engagement and virtual spectatorship in resource-constrained African contexts. This study seeks to bridge this gap by examining a Nigerian case study of digital theatre convergence.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

The following questions guide the study:

1. How does livestreaming influence audience engagement in theatrical performance?
2. What opportunities does digital theatre convergence create for theatre practitioners?
3. What challenges emerge when integrating digital technologies into theatrical productions?
4. How does virtual spectatorship reshape the relationship between performer, audience, and performance space?

LITERATURE REVIEW

Digital Theatre and Livestreamed Performance

Digital theatre refers to theatrical practices that incorporate digital technologies into production, performance, dissemination, or audience interaction. The growth of digital platforms has enabled performances to transcend geographical limitations, creating opportunities for wider audience participation and accessibility.

Virtual Spectatorship and Audience Engagement

Virtual spectatorship has transformed traditional understandings of audience participation. Through social media and livestreaming platforms, audiences can engage with performances remotely while simultaneously interacting with performers and other audience members.

African Perspectives on Digital Performance

Although digital theatre scholarship has expanded globally, African contributions remain comparatively limited. Existing studies highlight both the opportunities and challenges associated with digital performance, particularly concerning technological infrastructure, accessibility, and cultural adaptation.

Recent scholarship has increasingly examined the emergence of digital theatre, virtual spectatorship, and livestreamed performance as significant developments in contemporary theatre practice. Studies reveal that digital technologies have expanded audience accessibility, encouraged new forms of participation, and transformed conventional understandings of liveness and performance space. Kanga (2022) observes that livestreamed performances developed innovative artistic strategies during the COVID-19 pandemic, while Hancock (2025) argues that technological mediation has broadened conceptions of live performance. Within the African context, Mbuk (2025) notes that digital performance has enabled theatre practitioners to transcend geographical barriers and engage wider audiences despite infrastructural limitations. Similarly, Onwe and Dugga (2025) identify livestreaming, virtual performance, and hybrid theatre as emerging performance models in Nigeria. These studies collectively demonstrate that digital theatre convergence has become an important area of inquiry, particularly regarding audience engagement, accessibility, liveness, and technological adaptation in contemporary performance practice.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

Philip Auslander's Theory of Liveness

Philip Auslander argues that live performance and mediated performance are increasingly interconnected rather than oppositional. His concept of liveness provides an analytical framework for understanding how livestreamed theatre maintains audience engagement despite physical separation.

Henry Jenkins' Convergence Culture Theory

Jenkins explains convergence as the flow of content across multiple media platforms and the active participation of audiences. This framework is particularly relevant for analysing the integration of theatre, social media, and livestreaming technologies in contemporary performance practice.

METHODOLOGY

This study adopted a qualitative case study research design.

The case study focused on the livestreamed production of Otun Rasheed's *The Third World War*, performed by final-year students in the Department of Theatre Arts at Plateau State University.

Data were collected through:

Observation of rehearsals and performance processes.

Facebook Live viewer analytics.
Audience comments and reactions during and after the livestream.
Informal audience feedback.
Documentation of the livestreaming process.

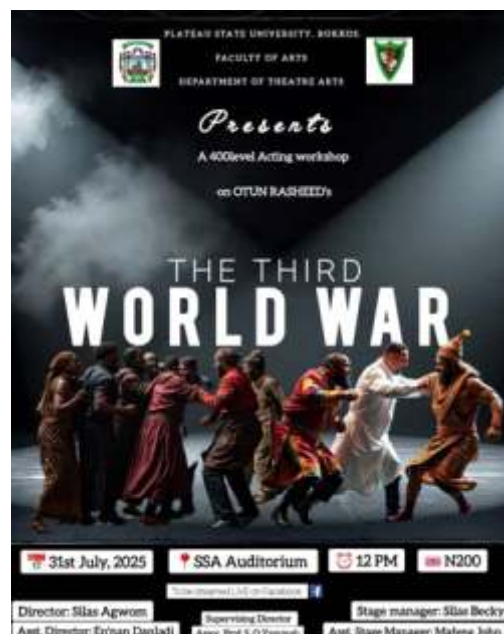
Data were analysed thematically to identify patterns relating to audience engagement, accessibility, technological challenges, and digital innovation.

Production Context and Documentation of the Performance

As part of the practical experimentation adopted in this study, the selected case study was a 400-level Acting Workshop production of Otun Rasheed's *The Third World War*, staged by final-year students of the Department of Theatre Arts, Faculty of Arts, Plateau State University, Bokoos. The production was presented in a hybrid format that combined conventional live theatre with digital dissemination via Facebook Live.

The performance was officially staged on 31 July 2025 at 12:00 PM at the SSA Auditorium, Plateau State University, Bokoos. In addition to the in-person audience at the venue, the production was livestreamed on Facebook Live to enable remote participation. This hybrid arrangement created an opportunity to investigate audience engagement across both physical and virtual performance spaces.

The production formed part of the department's practical exploration of digital theatre convergence and provided empirical material for examining how livestreaming technologies influence accessibility, spectatorship, and theatrical communication.



(Picture 1: Showing the Production flyer)

CASE STUDY: *THE THIRD WORLD WAR*

Synopsis of the Play

Otun Rasheed's *The Third World War* is a socio-political drama that explores the devastating consequences of global conflict, political ambition, corruption, and the abuse of power. Through a combination of satire, symbolism, and dramatic conflict, the play presents a world threatened by selfish leadership, ideological divisions, and the pursuit of dominance by powerful individuals and nations. The narrative exposes how greed, poor governance, and leaders' failure to prioritise human welfare can escalate tensions, plunging society into large-scale destruction.

The play portrays the suffering of ordinary citizens caught in political struggles and warfare. It highlights themes of injustice, human rights violations, social inequality, and the destructive effects of violence on communities. Through its characters and dramatic situations, the play questions leaders' moral responsibility and challenges audiences to reflect on the consequences of political irresponsibility and the pursuit of power at the expense of peace and collective well-being.

Furthermore, *the Third World War* serves as a warning against the dangers of unchecked political rivalry and global instability. While depicting the possibility of widespread conflict, the play simultaneously advocates dialogue, unity, accountability, and peaceful coexistence as essential tools for preventing societal collapse. Its relevance extends beyond the drama's fictional world, offering commentary on contemporary political realities and the urgent need for responsible leadership in an increasingly interconnected world.

In the Plateau State University production, the play's themes of conflict, leadership, and social responsibility were communicated to both in-person and virtual audiences via a Facebook Live stream. This digital adaptation expanded audience access to the production and provided an opportunity to examine how technology-mediated performance can facilitate broader engagement with socially relevant theatrical content.

Directorial Concept and Staging Approach

The directorial vision for *The Third World War* was centred on demonstrating how contemporary theatre can effectively integrate digital technologies into conventional stage performance to expand audience reach and engagement. The production sought to maintain the artistic integrity of live theatre while simultaneously embracing digital convergence through livestreaming on Facebook Live. This approach was informed by the understanding that theatre in the digital age must adapt to changing audience behaviours and technological realities without abandoning its core performative qualities.

The director adopted a hybrid performance model that combined traditional stagecraft with digital mediation. While the actors performed before a physical audience in the conventional theatre setting, equal consideration was given to the virtual audience who accessed the performance remotely. This dual-audience approach influenced several production decisions, including stage arrangement, actor positioning, and camera placement. The objective was to ensure that both physical and online audiences could effectively follow the dramatic action and engage with the performance.

The staging approach emphasised visibility and accessibility. The performance space was arranged to accommodate camera coverage while maintaining the aesthetic requirements of the live production. Strategic camera positioning enabled the capture of key dramatic moments, character interactions, and stage movements for livestream viewers. Lighting was carefully managed to enhance visual clarity and ensure performers remained visible on screen throughout the production, as the livestream served as an extension of the performance space. Staging decisions considered both theatrical presentation and digital transmission requirements.

Furthermore, the production employed a minimal but functional stage design that allowed for smooth actor movement and uninterrupted camera coverage. The emphasis was placed on performance, dialogue, and thematic communication rather than elaborate scenic effects. This approach ensured that the central themes of conflict, leadership, war, and social responsibility remained the primary focus of audience attention.

A significant aspect of the directorial vision was audience inclusivity. By livestreaming the production through Facebook Live, the director sought to remove geographical barriers and create opportunities for participation beyond the physical venue. This digital strategy enabled individuals who could not attend the performance in person to observe, react, comment, and engage with the production in real time. Consequently, the traditional boundaries between performer, audience, and performance space were expanded through digital technology.

Overall, the directorial concept reflected an experimental and innovative approach to contemporary theatre practice. The production demonstrated how digital technologies can complement live performance by enhancing accessibility, promoting audience participation, and extending the reach of theatrical productions while preserving the essential characteristics of theatre as a live and communal art form.

Digital Adaptation Strategies

The production incorporated digital technologies through:

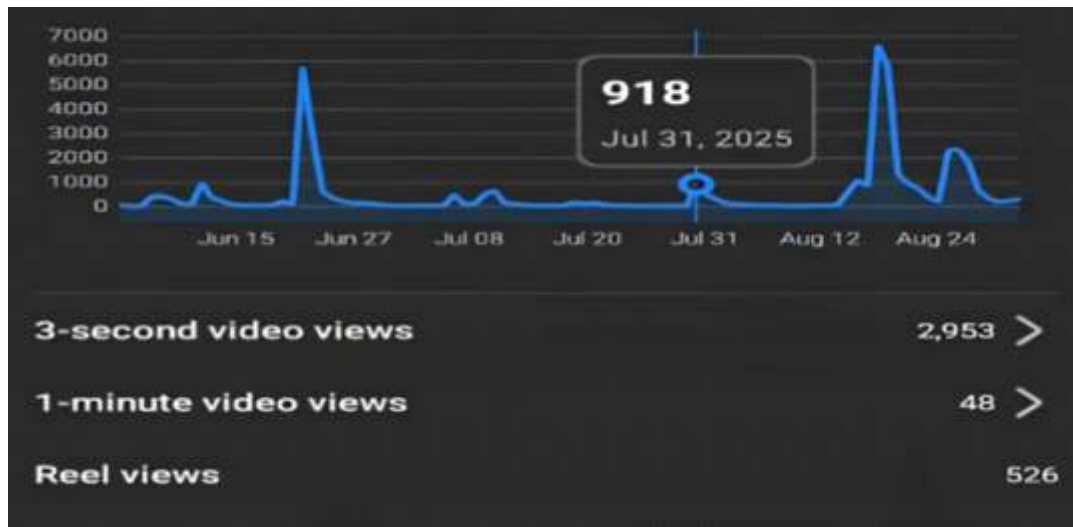
- Facebook Live livestreaming.
- Online publicity and promotion.
- Camera placement and digital documentation.
- Remote audience participation.

These strategies enabled the performance to reach audiences beyond the physical venue.

FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

Audience Reach and Engagement

The findings indicate that livestreaming expanded audience access and enabled participation by individuals unable to attend in person.



(Picture 2. Shows the statistics of the number of people who viewed the livestreamed production)

Opportunities Created by Digital Theatre Convergence

The study identified several opportunities:

- Increased accessibility.
- Wider audience reach.
- Enhanced visibility of theatre productions.
- Opportunities for audience interaction.
- New modes of theatrical dissemination.

Challenges Encountered

Several challenges emerged:

- Poor network connectivity.
- Low audio quality.
- Funding limitations.
- Delayed performance schedule.
- Facebook content restrictions.

These challenges demonstrate that digital theatre convergence requires adequate technological infrastructure and planning.

Digital Theatre and Liveness

Applying Auslander's theory of liveness, the findings reveal that virtual audiences experienced a mediated form of theatrical presence. While physical co-presence was absent, digital

technologies created alternative forms of audience engagement and participation.

Theatre Convergence and Audience Participation

Using Jenkins' convergence culture framework, the study demonstrates how theatre and social media converged to create participatory experiences. Audience members engaged with the production through comments, reactions, and online discussions.

LIMITATIONS OF THE STUDY

The study encountered several limitations:

- Limited funding.
- Inadequate streaming equipment.
- Internet connectivity issues.
- Restricted audience data collection.
- Focus on a single case study.

These limitations may affect the generalizability of the findings.

CONCLUSION

This study demonstrates that digital theatre convergence significantly expands audience access and participation beyond traditional performance spaces. Through the livestreamed production of *The Third World War*, digital technologies enabled virtual spectatorship and broader audience reach. However, challenges including network instability, funding limitations, platform restrictions, and technical difficulties highlight the complexities of integrating technology into theatre practice.

The study contributes to emerging scholarship on African digital theatre. It underscores the need for further research on virtual audience engagement, digital performance cultures, and technology-mediated theatrical experiences within Nigeria and beyond.

RECOMMENDATIONS

- a. Theatre practitioners should invest in improved digital infrastructure.
- b. Future productions should incorporate professional audio and video equipment.
- c. Theatre institutions should provide training in digital performance practices.
- d. Further studies should investigate audience reception using larger datasets.
- e. Comparative studies should be conducted across different African theatre contexts.

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